

The Small-Business Security Checklist

The 7 settings that stop 90% of the attacks

Most attacks on a small business aren't genius hacks - they walk through a door that was left unlocked. Here are the seven locks. None of them cost much, and most take an afternoon. Together they stop the overwhelming majority of what we break down on the channel. Print this, work down the list, and tick each one off.

1



Turn on multi-factor authentication - on your email first.

Add a second step (a code or a tap on your phone) so a stolen password alone can't get in. Start with the account that can reset all the others: your email. Use an authenticator app instead of text-message codes wherever you can.

STOPS: Account takeover - and the hijacked-inbox chain that turns into wire fraud.

2



Switch on automatic updates - everywhere.

Phones, computers, browsers, and the router or Wi-Fi box. Most break-ins walk through a known hole that a free update already closed weeks ago. Set things to update overnight and forget about it.

STOPS: Malware and payment-card skimmers that exploit out-of-date software.

3



Back up your data - and test that it actually restores.

Keep 3 copies, on 2 kinds of media, with 1 of them offline or offsite. A backup you've never restored is a guess, not a safety net - so do a test restore once. This is your off-switch for ransomware.

STOPS: Ransomware, hardware failure, and the insider who wipes everything on the way out.

4



Use a password manager - a different password for every account.

One leaked password should never open every door. A manager makes long, unique passwords effortless: you remember one, it remembers the rest. Length beats clever symbols.

STOPS: Credential stuffing - attackers replaying one breached password across your accounts.

5



Give each person their own login, with the least access they need.

No shared 'front desk' account. Do day-to-day work from a standard (non-admin) account, keep the admin login separate, and cut off access the same day someone leaves.

STOPS: Insider damage, and an attacker who lands on one account and roams the whole network.

6



Confirm any money or banking change by phone - and stop email spoofing.

Before you change a vendor's bank details or send a wire, call a number you already know - never the one in the email. If you own a domain, switch on SPF, DKIM, and DMARC so crooks can't send mail that looks like it's from you.

STOPS: Business email compromise (BEC) - the costliest attack hitting small businesses.

7



Encrypt your laptops and lock down your Wi-Fi.

Turn on full-disk encryption (BitLocker on Windows, FileVault on Mac) so a stolen laptop is just a lost device, not a data breach. Use WPA2/WPA3, change the router's default admin password, and put guests on their own separate network.

STOPS: A lost or stolen laptop turning into a reportable data breach.